

Revolution: replacing old monarchies



Political change in Europe gathered pace in the 17th century, as the power of monarchy and aristocracy was challenged. Renaissance humanism had brought into question any divine right to rule, and in many places the classical idea of a democratic republic had been revived. Naturally, such ideas met with resistance, so the old orders were often removed by force. The first revolution of the Enlightenment was in England, when the monarchy was overthrown and power transferred to Parliament. This shift in political power prompted Hobbes and Locke to develop the theory of the social contract, and their political philosophy inspired philosophers and

political thinkers elsewhere. In France, Voltaire, Diderot and especially Rousseau seized upon the idea of the social contract to explain the necessity of change, while in America, Englishman Thomas Paine translated philosophy into political activism. The revolutions in America and France had similar political ideals embodied in the mottoes 'Life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness' and '*Liberté, égalité, fraternité*', both inspired by Enlightenment philosophy.